

AI and the Human Factor

Rethinking hospitality in an age of intelligent technology

By Mladen Janev

Founder & Hospitality Strategy Advisor
Walton Hospitality Initiative

*Technology can do more.
So we can be more human.*

01 Why People Travel

People travel for many reasons. At the heart of travel is a deeply human desire — to step away, reconnect, discover, gain perspective and experience something beyond the familiar.

Hospitality begins within that human need. Travel creates space — space away from routine, space for reflection, and space for new encounters.

02 The Hotel as a Human Place

A hotel is not simply a room sold for a night. It is a place where one person temporarily enters another environment — and where the quality of that experience depends on people, place, attention and understanding.

Behind every reservation is a person leaving one setting and entering another — carrying expectations, needs, memories and perhaps a desire for something that cannot be expressed entirely through a booking form.

03 The Arrival of AI

Artificial intelligence can process information, identify patterns, support decisions and remove repetitive work. It may give hospitality professionals more intelligence and more time.

For many in our industry, management time has traditionally been consumed by gathering, reconciling and presenting information. AI has the potential to reduce that burden and return time to managers and teams.

But the real opportunity is not simply what AI can do.

It is what we choose to do with the time and understanding it gives us.

04 A Choice About Time

If AI gives us more time, what do we choose to do with it? Better management? Deeper understanding of guests and colleagues? A stronger connection with destinations? Or simply another layer of automation?

05 Putting the Guest at the Centre

As we consider new technology, a simple test can help guide our decisions: “How will this use of AI help us serve the guest better?”

A More Human Tomorrow

AI can give hospitality professionals more intelligence and more time.

The real opportunity is what we choose to do with it.

Perhaps the most important question is not what AI can do, but what we, as humans, choose to do.

*More technology.
A more human hospitality.*



Different places.
Deeper perspectives.
A more connected world.

“Hospitality begins when one human being makes another feel welcome.”

”



PEOPLE
at the heart



HOSPITALITY
with purpose



DESTINATIONS
that matter



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02

A Human Beginning

Why do people travel?

People leave their everyday environment for many reasons: to rest, to reconnect, to discover, to gain a different perspective, or simply to have time to think.

Travel creates space — space away from routine, space for reflection, and space for new encounters.

For some, travel is a search for renewal. For others, it is curiosity, adventure, learning or the opportunity to see familiar questions from a different point of view.

Human beings have long sought places beyond everyday life in which to pause, reflect, recover their sense of direction or reconnect with something meaningful.

Hospitality sits close to this human desire for change. A hotel is not simply a room sold for a night. It is a place in which a person temporarily enters a different environment and, ideally, feels welcome within it.

Behind every reservation is a person leaving one setting and entering another — carrying expectations, needs, memories and perhaps a desire for something that cannot be expressed entirely through a booking form.

Hospitality before the transaction

The commercial transaction may be the visible beginning of a hotel stay.

But the human experience begins earlier. It begins with the decision to go somewhere. It continues through arrival, encounter, attention and the feeling that the place — and the people within it — have responded to the guest as a person.

The guest does not arrive as an empty booking reference. They arrive with a reason for travelling, a personal context and expectations shaped by their own life.

The quality of hospitality depends partly on whether that human reality is recognised — not just in words, but in the way the experience is designed and delivered.

In a world of increasing automation, this human beginning is worth remembering. It is the foundation on which meaningful hospitality is built.

“Hospitality begins when the human encounter comes before the transaction.”



A different perspective can change everything.

More than movement

Travel is not only about distance. It is about what it gives us.

**REST**

Time to recharge.

**RECONNECT**

With people, nature and oneself.

**DISCOVER**

New places, ideas and perspectives.

**REFLECT**

Time to think beyond routine.

**BELONG**

A temporary sense of place.



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03

The Arrival of AI

Opportunity, complexity and a more human future

A powerful new capability

Artificial intelligence can process vast amounts of information, identify patterns, support decisions and remove repetitive work. It can give hospitality professionals more intelligence, more time and new ways to understand guests, markets and performance.

In a data-rich industry, AI has the potential to reduce manual effort, improve forecasting, personalise communication and help teams focus on what really matters — higher quality guest experiences.

Many hotels are already using AI in areas such as demand forecasting, revenue management, guest messaging, operational planning and content creation. The technology is evolving quickly, and its potential is significant.

But with this opportunity comes a set of important questions.

AI is a tool — a powerful one — but it is not a strategy. Its value depends on how it is used, what problems it is meant to solve, and whether it ultimately helps people deliver better hospitality.

Beyond efficiency

Efficiency is important, but it is not the only measure of progress. Hospitality is not a purely operational business — it is a people business.

The real opportunity is not simply what AI can do, but what it allows us as humans to do.

If AI can take on more of the routine, it may give teams more time for meaningful interactions, creative problem-solving and thoughtful decision-making.

Used well, AI can support better understanding of guests, help teams anticipate needs and create more space for the human qualities that make hospitality special: empathy, judgment, curiosity and care.

The challenge is to ensure that in the pursuit of efficiency we do not lose sight of what gives hospitality its value — the human connection.

“AI can do more.
So we can be
more human.”



New perspectives often begin away from the everyday.

Key opportunities for hospitality



BETTER INSIGHTS

Deeper understanding of guests, markets and performance.



MORE TIME

Less routine work, more time for people.



MORE PERSONALISATION

More relevant and timely guest experiences.



NEW POSSIBILITIES

Creative ideas and smarter decision-making.



A MORE SUSTAINABLE APPROACH

Greater efficiency can support more responsible and resilient hospitality.



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04

A Choice About Time

What do we want to do with the time AI gives us?

More time is within reach

One of the most significant promises of AI is the ability to take on routine tasks — processing information, identifying patterns, generating reports and supporting decisions.

Tasks that once took hours may now take minutes. What was manual can often be automated. What was reactive can become proactive.

For hospitality professionals, this can create a valuable opportunity: more time.

Less time spent gathering data, reconciling reports or producing standard analysis can free up capacity for deeper understanding, more meaningful conversations and greater focus on the guest experience.

But time alone does not guarantee better outcomes.

The real question is not only how much time AI can give us, but what we choose to do with it.

A more human agenda

If we use this time well, we can look beyond the numbers and engage more deeply with people — guests, colleagues, owners and our wider destination communities.

We can spend more time understanding guest needs, listening to feedback, observing behaviour and anticipating future expectations.

We can collaborate more, solve problems more creatively and focus on the details that make a stay memorable.

We can also take more time to think strategically — about how our hotels fit within their destinations, how we create sustainable value, and how we remain relevant in a changing world.

AI can give us time. But it cannot decide for us. The choice is ours.

It is not simply a question of doing more, but of doing what matters — the things that make hospitality human, distinctive and valuable for the long term.

“Time is not just a resource in hospitality. It is a chance to be more human.”



A little more time can open a broader perspective.

Time for what matters



PEOPLE

More time to listen, connect and support our teams.



GUESTS

More time to understand needs, preferences and expectations.



IDEAS

More time for creative thinking and innovation.



PLACES

More time to engage with our destinations and communities.



A BRIGHTER TOMORROW

More time to build a more sustainable and resilient hospitality industry.



PEOPLE
at the heart



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05

A More Human Tomorrow

People, purpose and the possibilities ahead

Technology as an enabler

AI is not here to replace the human in hospitality. It is a tool — a powerful one — that can support people, improve decisions and create new possibilities.

Used well, it can help teams understand guests more deeply, work more efficiently and focus on what truly matters. It can give us time, insight and perspective.

But technology alone cannot create hospitality. The warmth of a welcome, the understanding of a guest's needs or the sense of belonging to a place still comes from people.

The future of hospitality will not be shaped by AI alone, but by how we choose to use it — and what we choose to prioritise alongside it.

Keeping perspective

As the industry continues to explore new technologies, it is important to keep a clear sense of perspective.

AI can support analysis, predict patterns and suggest options. But it cannot replace human judgement, experience or values.

Hospitality is not only about what is possible, but also about what is meaningful.

A human-centred path forward

A more human tomorrow is not about rejecting technology. It is about using it wisely — in a way that supports people, places and long-term value.

This means designing a future in which AI and people work together — where technology handles more of the routine, and people have greater space to focus on empathy, creativity and connection.

It also means thinking beyond individual properties to the wider ecosystem: hotels, destinations, communities and the environments that make travel worthwhile.

The real opportunity is not just to be more efficient, but to be more human — and to create hospitality experiences that are more thoughtful, more sustainable and more valuable for guests, communities and the industry as a whole.

“A more human tomorrow is possible when technology supports people — and people remain at the heart of hospitality.”



A more human tomorrow is a brighter one.

Five guiding principles

As we look to the future, five principles can help keep us on the right path.



PEOPLE FIRST

Technology should support, not replace, the human in hospitality.



PURPOSE-LED

Use innovation to create meaningful and lasting value.



PLACES THAT MATTER

Support destinations, communities and natural environments.



RESPONSIBLE PROGRESS

Balance opportunity with ethical, social and environmental impact.



A BRIGHTER TOMORROW

A more human, resilient and sustainable hospitality industry is within reach.



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06

A Conversation,
Not a Conclusion*Ideas worth sharing. Questions worth exploring.*

Looking ahead

Throughout this publication we have explored the opportunities, challenges and human implications of AI in hospitality.

There are no simple answers. But there is a clearer understanding that technology alone will not define the future. The future will be shaped by the choices we make — as individuals, as organisations and as an industry.

Hospitality has always been about people — and it is our responsibility to ensure that remains true, even as the tools, contexts and challenges around us change.

This is not a conclusion. It is an invitation — to think, to question and to continue the conversation.

“The future of hospitality will be shaped not by technology alone, but by the choices people make — and by whether those choices preserve the human purpose of hospitality.”

Open questions for further thought

These questions are offered as a starting point for continued discussion. There are no right or wrong answers — but they may help us think differently about what comes next.

- 01 Where does hospitality begin — before or at the transaction?
- 02 What can AI give hospitality, and what can hospitality give back to AI?
- 03 If AI gives us more intelligence and more time, what do we choose to do with it?
- 04 How can technology expand a hotel's choices rather than narrow them?
- 05 What happens when efficiency improves but human connection declines?
- 06 Who is actually running the hotel — the technology, the process, or the people?
- 07 How can we ensure that a more efficient hospitality industry is also a more human, sustainable and resilient one?

Research and further reading

This publication has been informed by academic literature, professional experience and ongoing conversation. Readers interested in exploring the research behind these ideas are invited to consult the original publications through their publishers, institutional libraries or authorised open-access sources.

- Kojima, H. & Doering, A. (2026). From applied philosophy to philosophizing tourism: Contemplation, conversation, and cross-disciplinarity.
- Munasinghe, S. et al. (2022). Hospitality beyond the commercial domain: A triadic conceptualisation of hospitality in tourism from a host-guest encounter perspective.
- Chen, C. et al. (2020). Tourism, dwelling and the relationship between people and place.
- Cohen, E. (2018). Philosophical, ethical and theological foundations of tourism.

Full references, including journal details and links, are available on request. Full-text articles are not reproduced or redistributed by Walton Hospitality Initiative.



Different perspectives lead to a brighter tomorrow.

Join the conversation

Hospitality evolves through people who share ideas, challenge assumptions and explore new possibilities. I welcome your thoughts, questions and different perspectives.



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Let's continue the conversation.

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